BHUVAN BAM & TANISHK BAGCHI

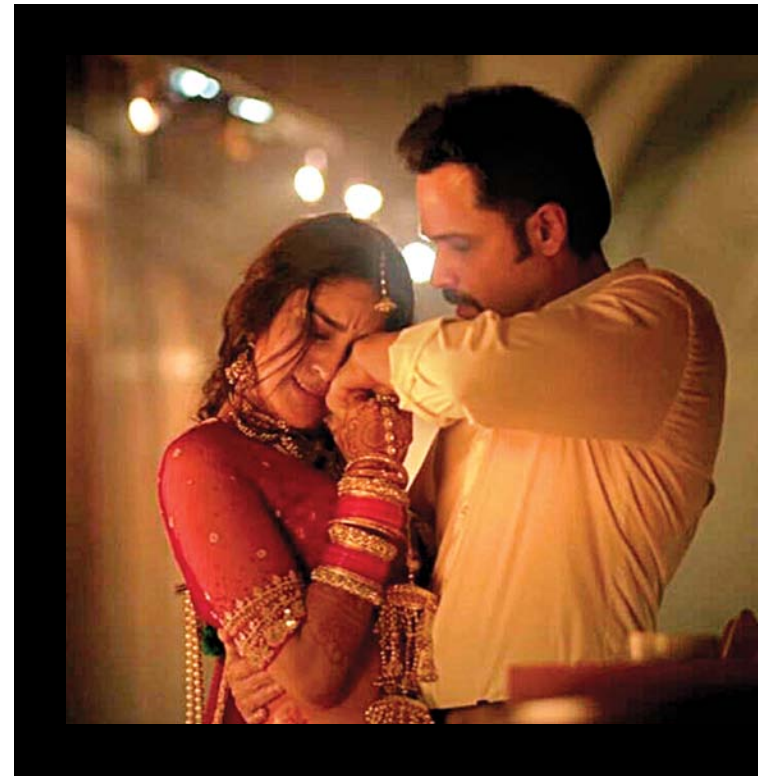
This brave new world—one that measures every click and view—isn't quite every artist's piece of cake. If virality is the goal, you need to have your finger firmly on that sometimes erratic millennial and Gen Z pulse. The youth of our country have never been a monolith and there has never been a single formula that can explain their wants and likes. The only thing that artists of today agree on is that youngsters like their art and entertainment in massive quantities and smaller sizes. Theirs is a feast of appetisers.

Technology, it must be said, has undoubtedly democratised the landscape but for artists, streaming services and social media are, of course, platforms where you showcase your talent, but they are also, at times, places where you get forgotten easily. Relevance is hard-won on YouTube and Instagram. You can't just have made news once. You have to keep making it. Even though our artists of the year—Bhuvan Bam and Tanishk Bagchi—have left their indelible stamp on 2021, both of them, it could be said, were locked in a state of perpetual arrival before they finally took off this year.

Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Bagchi says, "It is all my hard work that is showing right now, but the thing is I haven't been able to enjoy success the way others do. I just have to keep on working." If the music composer wanted, he wouldn't have to look far for laurels to rest on. He made it to Billboard's 'Global Excl. US' chart with 'Lut Gaye' and 'Raataan Lambiyan' in 2021. With 1.2 billion streams, he was the most heard artist on the music streaming app Gaana. Within 24 hours of his 'Dance Meri Rani' dropping on YouTube in the last week of December, it was viewed 20 million times. Bagchi, it is clear, gave 2021 its soundtrack.

Bhuvan Bam, too, did something remarkable. He didn't just bring us some cheer towards the end of a bad year with *Dhindora*, he made the show available for free on YouTube instead of opting for a paid OTT platform. "I do take pride in the fact that my content is almost always free," he says. "But frankly, I have stopped thinking of what I do in monetary terms. The more work I put out, the more chance there is for a big director to look at me and say, 'It might be time to consider him for something big'. I have that kind of optimism now." *Dhindora's* eight episodes have together been viewed more than 300 million times. Though Bam refers to it as "an audition", the show is also obviously the big stage.

It was in 2015 that Bam officially started his YouTube channel, 'BB Ki Vines'. Technologically speaking, the videos he shot with the front camera of his phone were basic—he didn't even use a tripod—but their spartan production, one felt, was always disguised by Bam's talent and ingenuity. The actor seemed to relish playing multiple roles. The last time we checked, he had created 19 characters for himself. "It was a gradual process," he says. "People didn't just like one or two characters, they seemed to be liking them all. That's how I got the idea of creating a family tree of my own." With *Dhindora*, Bam adds, he wanted to take his personas—the mother Janki, father Babloo, Titu Mama, Bancho—beyond the walls of his room and see how far they could go. "It would be difficult but I wanted to try."



CLICKS INTO PLACE
The music video for the Tanishk Bagchi-composed 'Lut Gaye' (left); and the many faces of Bhuvan Bam in *Dhindhora*

Bam's use of VFX in *Dhindora* is both conspicuous and seamless. You would think an actor playing nearly a dozen parts would be overwhelming but Bam brings to each character an affability and passion that proves instantly charming. More importantly, perhaps, he has now set a kind of precedent—in terms of technology and viewership—that other content creators on YouTube might find hard to match. For Bam, there has clearly never been a short cut to success. He has only ever pushed the envelope more.

Compared to Bam's 24.9 million subscribers, there are other YouTubers like Carry Minati who have a larger online following (33.7 million subscribers), but Bam, strangely enough, is more of a household name, more of a ticket-holder to the Indian zeitgeist. Unlike comedians like Vir Das and Munawar Faruqui, Bam is also uncontroversial. *Dhindora,* for instance, is social satire, yes, but it doesn't once resort to contentious commentary. Bam, for his part, insists he isn't a comedian: "If I sit with you for just 10 minutes, I'll bore the hell out of you. I believe that I have a decent